

UNDRO Registry and Mail Unit

RESPONSIBILITIES

1. The responsibilities of the UNDRO Registry and Mail Unit are:
 - (a) To receive all official communications from the Co-ordination Centre, Mail and Pouch Services, to open, codify, register and circulate them.
 - (b) To codify, register and dispatch by mail or pouch all outgoing communications.
 - (c) To create a "Subject Codification Manual", to continuously update it and modify it so as to suit the necessities of UNDRO.
 - (d) To establish, loan, maintain and service all current and semi-current files.
 - (e) Periodically to control semi-current files.
 - (f) To screen non-current files prior to disposal or transfer to the Historical Archives.
 - (g) To select, preserve, administer and service historical records and to control access to them.

CODIFICATION MANUAL

2. A central "Subject Codification Manual" will be created and continuously updated and modified according to requirements. The general principle followed will be to establish main subject headings to which sub-subject files are added as required, further broken down by source. The Manual will also show cross-references.
3. Modifications, additions and changes to the Manual will be communicated to UNDRO staff for their information.

MAIL AND POUCH CORRESPONDENCE

Reception, Opening, Codification and Registration of Official Incoming Correspondence

4. A Chronological File of all incoming correspondence entering UNDRO will be maintained by Registry. This file will consist of duplicates or photocopies of incoming material. Duplicate copies, if supplied by the sender, may be used for cross-referencing purposes, in which case photocopies will be made for the incoming chron file.
5. If a letter refers to documents enclosed, all copies of the letter will be marked "enclosures attached" or "no enclosures attached", as the case may be.

Routing of Correspondence for Which Files Are in Registry

6. Having been coded, correspondence will be forwarded in the appropriate file(s), which may be newly opened if the subject has not previously arisen.
7. Credentials, legal documents, deeds, maps, photographs and material of similar nature will never be hole-punched or mutilated. They will be placed in a pre-punched envelope with a notation on it.
8. Above the correspondence will be placed an "Action Sheet". Circulation will be marked by the Registry staff on the "Action Sheet".
9. Circulation will be decided according to reference between the subject of the letter and UNDRO's management and divisional structure. The circulation given will be noted on a "Movement of File" card.
10. A "File Contents" card will be maintained by Registry containing brief details on the content.

Routing of Correspondence for Which Files Are Not in Registry

11. Registry will send the new correspondence to the officer in possession of the file. Registry will mark the name of the officer, the file number and the mention "loose" on the IN/CHRON copy for future reference.

Handling of Action Correspondence

12. Officers to whom the file is circulated will make their comments on the Action Sheet in ink or in typescript: in this way a permanent record will be maintained of the treatment accorded to the correspondence. It must be clear by whom the comments were made, and on what date.
13. Officers proposing a draft reply, or other outgoing communication, will do so on a separate sheet of paper placed in the file behind the Action Sheet itself. Once the draft is approved and typed, the draft itself will be removed by the typist so saving the file from becoming unnecessarily bulky.
14. The officer responsible for action on incoming correspondence is also responsible for marking the Action Sheet, "Action completed" if action has been taken. If there is likely to be more than one week's delay before action can be completed (e.g. due to the absence on mission of another officer who must be consulted), the Action Officer is responsible for marking the Action Sheet "B.F." (Bring Forward) + date + signature. The Registry will then return the file to him on that date. The "Bring Forward" procedure will be used also to ensure that UNDRO receives replies required from its own outgoing correspondence, and otherwise as required by the circumstances of the case.

Outgoing Correspondence

15. All outgoing correspondence will bear an UNDRO reference number (i.e. the number of the file in which the correspondence belongs). If the letter under reply bore a reference number, this should be quoted also.

If an outgoing letter is the first action, file number will be placed on the copies by the Registry.

16. When an outgoing letter has been signed, the secretary to the signing officer will send it and all copies to the Registry. The original signed letter with its envelope, the green, yellow, pink and white copies will be sent to the Registry.
17. Registry will place copies as follows:
 - Green - Registry file (in file folder if file is out)
 - Yellow - float file
 - Pink - chron file
 - White - for cross-reference purposes if required
18. Registry will check any enclosures, if indicated on an outgoing letter by (...) on the left margin of the letter, and then dispatch it.

Handling of Files

19. Officers are responsible for files charged to them. A "Transit Slip" will be sent to Registry when the file is transferred to another officer. Staff emptying OUT-trays and passing files from one officer to another will be responsible for seeing that a "Transit Slip" is filled in and sent to Registry for each file transferred. Should the officer frequently pass files from office to office, he may wish to maintain an internal log while the file remains charged to him.
20. As soon as the officer concerned has completed the action, and the file is no longer needed, he will return it to Registry. It must be remembered that if a file remains with the officer for a long time, it may no longer be up to date. Removals from or additions to the files as well as changes in title or number may be made only by Registry.

Personal or Private Mail

21. Mail marked "Personal" or "Private" will be sent unopened to the addressee. Mail not so marked but which appears to be of a personal nature will be forwarded to the addressee unopened with a note on the envelope requesting the letter to be returned to the Registry for processing if it concerns official business.
22. A letter which is not marked "Personal" or "Private" on the envelope but is found when opened to be of personal nature will be resealed and marked "Opened by Registry" and initialled by the Registry staff member who opened it.
23. To avoid difficulties, every staff member who has a fixed residence is requested to arrange to receive private mail at his private address.

CABLES AND TELEX MESSAGES

24. There is no essential difference between a cable and a letter: both form part of UNDRO's records. However, a cable (the term is here

used to describe all messages other than letters or printed material) is ipso facto of a more urgent character than other forms of communication, whether it requires an answer or simply conveys information. Given the special nature of UNDRO's work in disaster situations, special arrangements, different from those common in other parts of the UN system, must be made. These are set out below.

25. ALL incoming cables whether received on the Co-ordination Centre machines, or from the UN Telecommunications Relay Centre or from the Cable Unit will first be sent to the Co-ordination Centre staff.

26. When the Relief Co-ordination function is being effected from the Centre during a disaster emergency, cables relating to that disaster will be distributed by the Centre staff as follows:

1 copy to the officer in charge of the Relief Co-ordination activities in the Centre (This is the official UNDRO file and action copy, and will be returned to Registry when the operation is completed.)

1 copy to the officer of Information Section in the Centre

1 copy to the officer of Logistics Section in the Centre

1 copy to the Co-ordination Centre chron file

remaining copies to Registry who will make extra copies as required and distribute to the Co-ordinator, the Director, the Chief and the Deputy Chief of Relief Co-ordination Division, Registry chron file, and Office of the Director-General, UNOG.

27. All other cables addressed to UNDRO will be distributed as follows:

1 copy to the Co-ordination Centre chron file

remaining copies to the Registry who will make extra copies as required to effect the following distribution:

- a) all messages: 1 copy each to the Co-ordinator, the Director, the Registry chron file and the Office of the Director-General, UNOG, and in addition
- b) relief co-ordination messages: 4 copies to RC Division
- c) prevention and planning messages: 3 copies to PP Division
- d) administrative messages: 2 copies to Administrative Officer

N.B. "Press telegrams" from OPI New York are for the Co-ordinator's personal information and will be distributed to him by the Registry. No chron copies will be retained.

Codification, Registration and Distribution of Messages

28. Registry will codify and register all cables and telexes in the same manner as when handling correspondence.

29. Except when the arrangements in para. 26 are in force, cables and telexes will be forwarded by Registry in the appropriate file(s) to the Action Officer. Copies of cables and telexes distributed by Registry to officers for their information will be marked "Info. Copy - Action Copy to _____".

30. When files for incoming messages are not in Registry, they will be sent to the Action Officer attached to an Action Sheet with the mention "loose".

Processing of Outgoing Messages

31. When outgoing communications are sent by cable the following modes of despatch are available:
- (a) message prepared on UN telegram form sent to Cable Unit or, outside working hours, direct to UN Telecommunications Relay Centre
 - (b) message drafted on plain paper for transmission by UNDRO telex to UN Telecommunications Relay Centre (i.e. normal outstation procedure, using word count in preamble and collation at the end)
 - (c) message drafted on plain paper for direct transmission by UNDRO telex to the distant station

Originating officers will decide which method of transmission is appropriate. Actual transmission will be effected by their secretaries or other general service staff as the situation demands.

32. Time-stamped return copies of messages on telegram forms (see para. 31 (a)) will be given to Registry to distribute as in para. 27 (plus one copy for Co-ordination Centre chron file).

Time-stamped copies of messages sent via UNDRO telex will be distributed from the Co-ordination Centre and Registry as in paras. 26 or 27, as conditions and circumstances dictate.

33. Originating officers are responsible for seeing that their copy of an outgoing message is placed on the appropriate file. No file is to be marked "Action completed" until this is done.
34. A Chron File with copies of all outgoing messages will be kept by Registry.

OTHER FUNCTIONS OF THE REGISTRY

Float File

35. Registry will circulate each day, to the Co-ordinator, Director, Chiefs of Divisions and Administrative Officer, a float file containing yellow copies of outgoing letters and messages and incoming messages, all filed in separate sections. At least twice weekly, the Registry will send the contents of the float files to the UNDRO Liaison Office in New York, by pouch.

Documentation

36. Registry will keep one English copy only of documents of General Assembly and ECOSOC Sessions. Documentation in all languages and additional information material should be requested from UNDRO's Reference Library.

Other

37. Registry can provide information on names, positions and addresses of UNDRO's correspondents and perform research work on subjects related to Registry files.

OTHER FUNCTIONS OF THE REGISTRY

First File

38. Registry will circulate each day, to the Co-ordinator, Director, Chief of Divisions and Administrative Officer, a First File containing copies of outgoing letters and messages and incoming messages, all filed in separate sections. At least twice weekly, the Registry will send the contents of the First File to the UNDRO Liaison Office in New York, by pouch.

Documentation

39. Registry will keep one English copy only of documents of General Assembly and ECOSOC sessions. Documentation in all languages and additional information material should be requested from UNDRO's Liaison Office.